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W E D N E S D A Y , J A N U A R Y 8 , 2 0 2 5

With vague hints, threats, Trump makes case to expand

Won't rule out coercion to take Greenland, regain Panama Canal; keeps pushing Canada

By David E. Sanger and Michael D. Shear
NEW YORK TIMES

President-elect Donald Trump refused on Tuesday to rule out the use of military or economic coercion to force Panama to give up control of the canal that America built more than a century ago and to push Denmark to sell Greenland to the United States.

In a rambling, hourlong news conference, Trump repeatedly returned to the theme of American sacrifice in building the canal and accused China, falsely, of operating it today. When pressed on the question of whether he might order the military to force Panama to give it up — in violation of treaties and other agreements reached during the Carter administration — or to do the same with Greenland, he said: “No, I can’t assure you on either of those two.”

“We need them for economic security — the Panama Canal was built for our military,” he said. Asked again if he would rule out the use of military force, he said: “I’m not going to commit to that. You might have to do something.”

Trump’s statements propelled his repeated calls for expanding US territory to a new level, one that is bound to roil three American allies — Panama; Denmark, which handles Greenland’s foreign and security affairs; and Canada, which he has mocked as America’s “51st state.” On Tuesday he

TRUMP, Page A6

Harsh cold adds to strain on shelters for homeless

By John Hilliard
GLOBE STAFF

Emergency shelters across the region were packed Tuesday as outreach teams fanned out to distribute hot meals and blankets to unhoused people, urging them to come in from the extreme weather that brought bitter, single-digit wind chills across the region.

In Boston, more than 600 people stayed at the Pine Street Inn’s four shelters overnight Monday into Tuesday, the facilities well over their capacity as areas like dining rooms were filled with cots and mats. Many shelters in Springfield, Fall River, and New Bedford were also at capacity, officials said.

“Our goal is literally to keep people alive in this sort of weather,” said Barbara V. Trevisan, a spokesperson for the Pine Street Inn.

The Pine Street’s outreach teams have been working around the clock in the extreme weather, she said; they also distribute meals and warm clothes to those who choose to remain outside. Even if someone doesn’t want to go to a shelter, sometimes they can be persuaded to warm up inside one of the shelter’s vans, she said.

“For the outreach teams, they know these people, they really do worry about them,” she said.

Advocates for the homeless said the all-out effort to assist people during the frigid weather —

HOMELESS, Page A7

‘It’s heartbreaking. You are ripping friendships apart.’

CHERYL BUCKMAN, a parent of a sixth-grader at Dever Elementary School, slated to close

Another try at school closings



JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

The Excel High School building would become a new anchor high school in South Boston, Superintendent Mary Skipper said.

With enrollment declining, city proposes shutting 3, merging 2; backlash likely

By Christopher Huffaker
GLOBE STAFF

Boston leaders called for closing three public schools and merging two others over the next year, the first of many moves to address declining enrollment and underused buildings, but one that will likely trigger the kind of backlash that previously prompted city officials to scuttle other closings.

Both Mayor Michelle Wu and Superintendent Mary Skipper said the city is better positioned to close underutilized buildings this time around because of improvements at other schools in the district.

The announcement is expected to be the first of a series of closures over the next five years to consolidate space.

The consolidation would affect about 1,300 students and more schools than in any year



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Dever Elementary has been under state receivership for years.

since 2011, when the district closed and merged more than a dozen.

The move comes as Wu enters her first reelection year as

mayor, and less than a year since the city backpedaled from a more ambitious goal of closing underutilized schools. But the district has long been under

pressure to shrink given that enrollment has declined more than 13 percent since 2006, to fewer than 49,000 last year, while costs to run the system have only grown.

Still, school closures often provoke fierce opposition from parents who fear the loss of community anchors and the risk that students will be bounced from one closure to another. Last spring, Skipper cited both the lack of community trust and the lack of better alternatives as reasons not to go forward with sweeping changes at that time.

Under the recommendation, Excel High School — the last remnant of the old South Boston High — would close, as would Dever Elementary in Dorchester and the Mary Lyon Pilot High School in Allston/Brighton. The Winthrop and Clap Elementary

SCHOOLS, Page A10

Three ingredients in a recipe for a longer life?

Researchers see something in celery, parsley, dark chocolate

By Kay Lazar
GLOBE STAFF

What if the next big thing to boost a healthier, longer life turned out to be — celery?

As scientists research ways to stretch the number of our healthy years, they are increasingly scrutinizing our metabolites, the thousands of molecules produced when our bodies break down the food we eat, the medicines we take, and the sea of chemicals we absorb from our environment.

Teams of researchers, armed with high-tech tools, are deciphering certain patterns of metabolites that may be linked to longer and healthier lives. One of the latest findings comes from an international team led by a Boston scientist that identified metabolites found in celery, parsley, and — in a chocoholic’s dream come true — dark chocolate that may help people age better and live longer.

More specifically, the team found higher levels of flavones, metabolites found in high levels

in parsley and celery, and salsolinol, a metabolite in dark chocolate, were present at surprisingly youthful levels in centenarians, suggesting the metabolites might be linked to longevity.

“This is information people can use right now to think about their diet,” said lead researcher Paola Sebastiani, director of the Center for Quantitative Methods and Data Science at Tufts Medical Center.

The findings do not mean people should rush out and consume huge quantities of these

LONGEVITY, Page A10

Chinatown open to change, but not too much

While rezoning could bring affordable housing, some see threat to character



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF/FILE 2

Planners would allow developers in parts of Chinatown to build structures up to 350 feet tall, under certain conditions.

By Danny McDonald
GLOBE STAFF

After decades of gentrification that has displaced thousands of Chinatown residents, the city is promising change.

Planners are pushing a multifaceted update to building rules they say will support more affordable housing and small business development.

The effort is getting a mixed reception. Advocates say the initiative would help maintain the neighborhood’s cultural and social fabric, but they question other elements that they believe are out of step with Chinatown’s needs.

The aspect of the zoning plan that perhaps most strongly signals a break with the past would strike the rules that gave birth to the Combat Zone in the neighborhood. It would largely be a symbolic move, as the heyday of the notorious den of sleaze — once home to strip clubs, X-rated theaters, peep shows, and adult bookstores — is long past.

Still, for those who advocate for Chinatown, removing a slice of the zoning that for years allowed the city’s only adult entertainment district to be in their neighborhood matters. It’s a mod-

CHINATOWN, Page A7

Massachusetts saw its largest population increase in 60 years between 2023 and 2024, fueled by the highest immigration levels in decades. **B1.**

Cases of the norovirus stomach bug are surging here this winter, mirroring a national trend. **B1.**

A college student who thought he was paying \$25 per session of PT got a bill for \$4,515. What happened? The Fine Print, **B5.**

Peter Yarrow, part of Peter Paul and Mary, one of the most popular folk acts of the 1960s, died at 86. **C9.**

The new year brings plenty of new restaurants to the scene. Check out 10 Devra First recommends. **G1.**



Blow by blow

Wednesday: Still windy. High 27-32. Low 16-21.

Thursday: Yes, still windy. High 29-34. Low 22-27.

High tide: 5:30 a.m., 6:05 p.m.

Sunrise: 7:13 Sunset: 4:29

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